

at the big digital timekeeper on the finish line, which is when I blacked out," he recalls.

"When you fall because of fatigue, your muscles aren't really working, which means that it's not easy to get up, but right then, a volunteer ran up to me, held my arm and helped me to get on my feet. I'm proud that I kept getting up and finished the race. I'm thankful to the volunteer who helped me get back up and continue. I'm extremely proud to have broken the 48-year-old national record, even if it's by a small margin. That means a lot to me," Sawan tells *Sportstar*.

Running for fun

Breaking a record that was already nearly two decades old when he was born was not always a goal for Sawan. Growing up in the village of Rada Bhakhed in Himachal Pradesh's Mandi district, he did not begin with lofty ambitions.

It is common to find runners pounding mountain trails early in the morning near Sawan's village, situated some 1400 metres above sea level, often in preparation for Army recruitment.

Sawan, however, had no such plans.

He got into running by chance. "A lot of children from my area run because they want to prepare for Army bharti (recruitment). But when I started running in school when I was in class 8, it was just because I enjoyed it. I wasn't thinking much about the future. I ran because it helped focus my mind and gave me a goal to chase. Then slowly, as I improved, my goals got bigger," he recalls.

Sawan wasn't actively looking to begin his competitive career either.

"My school didn't have a big playing ground, but one day my PT teacher took me to another school where an inter-school competition was being held. I participated in my first race, which was an 800m event. I remember I came third, which really motivated me.

"I wanted to win a school medal, then a district medal, then a state



Carving a niche: Sawan Barwal's first international medal came in 2023 when he won a bronze in the Asian Half Marathon Championships in Dubai.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

medal, then a national medal, and eventually become an international athlete. Every time I won a medal, I kept thinking about what I could accomplish next," Sawan told *Sportstar*.

His talent became evident quickly. He started as an 800m runner and progressed from the school level to the state and eventually the national level. In 2015, he finished fourth in the men's 3,000m at the Under-18 National Championships. He had not medalled, but it was enough to keep him in the sport.

Natural ability

Sawan, despite not harbouring ambitions of joining the military, was recruited by the Army the following year. He is currently a havaldar with the Engineering Corps. His coaches there quickly recognised where his strengths lay.

"When we were deciding on recruiting athletes, we performed a VO2 max test on Sawan. His VO2 max reading was 78. That's really high. The very elite Kenyan runners have a VO2 max of between 75 and 85. So we knew Sawan had potential in long-distance running," Army chief athletics coach Younis Khan explained.

Despite his physical gifts, Sawan had to wait another five years to win his first medal, a silver in the 10,000m at the Senior National Federation Cup in 2022.

The following year, his first international honour came, a bronze medal at the Asian Half Marathon Championships.

Despite progressing steadily in long-distance track events, Sawan initially held off on moving to the marathon.

"The first time I thought about running in the marathon was in 2023. But because we had the Asian Games that year and because I had already